person of a godman who is not strictly a Hindu, but a Sikh—the self-styled Baba Gurmeet Ram Rahim Singh Insan, whose name is a compound of Sikh, Hindu and Muslim names with 'Insan' meaning 'Human', and whose jailing in August 2017 precipitated a crisis across Punjab, Haryana and Delhi.

The flamboyant, jewellery-bedecked Gurmeet Singh had a reputation for sexually exploiting his female followers, but only two of them had the courage to sue. The case took fifteen years and 200 sittings of the court before he was convicted; during this time, numerous efforts were made by the Baba's devotees to pressure the investigators, the police, the judges and the complainants to withdraw the suit, but they did not give in.

Baba Gurmeet Ram Rahim Singh Insan was always a peculiar godman, eschewing spiritual asceticism for gaudy showmanship and ostentatious living. He liked his hair long, his motorcycles powerful, his cars expensive, his attire sequinned and his women clingy. He performed in popular music videos of his own composition—his biggest hit is called 'Love Charger'—and had a feature film made about himself called *Messenger of God*. This unlikely 'Rockstar Baba', however, amassed a mass following of fanatic worshippers estimated at over ten million.

He or his henchmen kept this flock together in ruthlessly effective ways. A crusading small-town journalist who reported the rape complaint against him was murdered in 2002. The Baba's movement, known as the Dera Sacha Sauda, amassed significant landholdings and property assets, and exerted influence over various aspects of life in the states of Punjab and Haryana; its reach extended to Delhi.

And yet the Dera Sacha Sauda fulfilled a genuine need in north Indian society, giving millions an identity and a standing they had not previously known. Sections of people who had long known only oppression found in the dera movement a measure of security, safety and dignity they and their families had not historically enjoyed, as well as (or so the cynics say) a simpler, more 'market-friendly' version of religious faith. The dera movement considerably predates Ram Rahim, and had